



Col Rathore presenting the Unsung Hero Award to former athlete Sriram Singh. PICS: R. V. MOORTHY

Rajasthan, we want to set up some centres of excellence with some top corporates who have their hearts in the right place. They will provide international-level facilities and guidance. In the next four years, we will have one stadium in every district for sure. Our ambition is even higher: one stadium in every *tehsil* of Rajasthan. We would create 50 stadiums per year. We will also start Khelo Rajasthan from this year, along the same lines as Khelo India. We will also have our own version of TOPS [Target Olympic Podium Scheme]. The best athletes will be supported by us. We have formed a new policy for sports, and we have formed a new youth policy as well," Rathore said.

Hailing Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Rathore said, "Sports has received an impetus since 2014. I have seen the whole spectrum of Indian sports. I have worked at the central and state levels in sports. Prime Minister Narendra Modi *ji* has started a revolution in Indian sports. Khelo India and TOPS started it, giving Indian sports a new standard.

"TOPS has marked a transformative moment for Indian sports, raising the profile and standards of athletes across the nation. This initiative brought in professional management to oversee all aspects of athlete preparation, including final training, boarding, and lodging, ensuring a seamless experience.

"Athletes were provided with daily access to top-tier facilities and sports science support, whether they were training in India or abroad. A groundbreaking addition was



Archer Pranjal Tholiya receives the Young Achiever Award from Col Rathore. Sportstar Editor Ayon Sengupta is at right.

the introduction of a pocket allowance, with the top 200 Olympic medal hopefuls each receiving Rs. 50,000 per month to aid in their training and development."

Rathore also highlighted the challenges athletes faced during his playing days, while emphasising significant improvements in facilities available to athletes today.

"I remember our colleagues from that era, when we used to travel by train. The accommodations we stayed in and the way we managed were vastly different back then. For breakfast, we often had simple meals like milk and jalebi. Just thinking about the nutritional value of those meals compared to what athletes have access to today is remarkable. It's incredible how far we've come in terms of nutrition and overall athlete support.

"Today, with events like Khelo India, there are seven or eight hotels reserved for the players, with AC accommodations. Players travel by air, and the games are broadcast in high definition, reflecting the level of professionalism involved. Each Khelo India event hosts over a thousand athletes, and they receive an annual stipend of Rs. 5 lakh for up to eight years. This is a huge step forward, providing substantial support to athletes — something we could only dream of back in the day."

Rathore also honoured Sriram Singh, one of India's greatest middle-distance runners, with the Unsung Champion Award, recognising his exceptional contributions to the sport. He presented the Young Achiever Award to Pranjal Tholiya, a rising star in Indian archery, celebrating her promising talent and achievements.